

Color, context, and the capsule wardrobe

Week 7, Lecture 2 · Looksmaxxing

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Undertone: how to read your skin tone and what it tells you
- High contrast vs. low contrast and why it changes your color choices
- Neutrals as the foundation of any practical wardrobe
- The three-color rule: a constraint that makes outfits read as intentional
- Dressing for context: the four registers and what each requires
- Building a five-look capsule wardrobe on a \$300 budget

Part 1: undertone and contrast

What undertone actually is

- Undertone is the underlying hue in your skin that persists regardless of tan, flush, or blemish.
- **Warm undertone:** yellow, golden, or peachy. Veins on the inner wrist appear greenish.
- **Cool undertone:** pink, red, or bluish. Veins appear blue or purple.
- **Neutral undertone:** a mix of both; veins appear blue-green.
- A second check: hold a piece of gold and a piece of silver fabric near your face. If gold looks more harmonious, you are likely warm; if silver, likely cool.
- Leconte (2017): undertone is distinct from skin depth (light vs. dark). A dark-skinned person can be cool; a pale person can be warm.

High contrast vs. low contrast

- **Contrast level** is the difference in value between your hair, skin, and eyes.
- High contrast: dark hair and light skin, or very light hair and dark skin. The color differences between your features are sharp.
- Low contrast: hair and skin are close in value, features blend together softly.
- The VOU (2023): "High-contrast men suit bold, defined color combinations; low-contrast men suit softer, more tonal outfits."
- Wearing a stark black-and-white outfit when you are low-contrast overwhelms your features. The outfit becomes the subject; you become the background.

Undertone and your best neutrals

- **Warm undertone:** best neutrals are camel, tan, olive, warm grey, off-white, tobacco brown.
- **Cool undertone:** best neutrals are true navy, charcoal, slate grey, true black, crisp white, burgundy.
- **Neutral undertone:** most neutrals work; experiment with both families.
- Neutrals are the foundation. Accent colors sit on top of them. Building the foundation first means the accents almost always work.

Part 2: color rules

The three-color rule

- Any outfit should contain no more than three distinct colors.
- One of those three should be a neutral from your foundation palette.
- The other two can be an accent and a secondary neutral, or two complementary accents.
- Leconte (2017): color theory in fashion is not about painting; it is about deliberate contrast or deliberate harmony.
- Violating the rule is possible but requires specific knowledge. For a beginner, the constraint prevents outfits that look chaotic.

Applying the rule: two examples

Warm undertone, high contrast

Cool undertone, low contrast

- Charcoal trousers (neutral)
 - White Oxford (neutral 2)
 - Brick red overshirt (accent)
 - Total: 3 colors, one warm accent
 - Reads: put-together, slightly warm
-
- Mid-grey trousers (neutral)
 - Pale blue t-shirt (adjacent neutral)
 - No third color needed
 - Total: 2 tonal colors
 - Reads: calm, intentional

What counts as a color

- Denim counts as a color: medium blue.
- Black shoes are a neutral. White sneakers are a neutral. Brown boots are a warm neutral.
- Accessories (belt, watch strap, bag) count toward the three. A brown belt with a navy outfit and a black watch is already at three.
- Patterns count as two colors: a navy-and-white striped shirt brings both navy and white into the outfit.

Part 3: context and the capsule

The four context registers

- **Casual:** t-shirt, chinos, clean sneakers. Works for lectures, errands, low-stakes social.
- **Smart casual:** fitted trousers or dark jeans, a button-up or OCBD, leather or suede shoes. First dates, dinner with friends, casual Fridays.
- **Business casual:** chinos or wool-blend trousers, an OCBD or sweater, leather shoes, no tie. Most office environments, networking events.
- **Business formal / dress:** suit or blazer with trousers, dress shirt, tie optional depending on industry. Interviews, presentations, formal events.
- Knowing which register a situation calls for is the first decision. Dressing one register above is usually safe. Two registers above reads as out of touch.

The five-look capsule

- The capsule is five complete outfits for five real contexts in your life.
- Every item should appear in at least two looks. Items that only appear in one look are inefficient unless they are very inexpensive.
- A realistic \$300 starter capsule for a student:
 - 2 pairs of trousers (\$40-60 each)
 - 2 Oxford or OCBD shirts (\$30-50 each)
 - 1 plain crewneck or half-zip (\$20-40)
 - 2 t-shirts (\$10-20 each)
 - 1 pair of clean casual shoes (\$50-80)
 - Total: roughly \$250-330 at budget retailers

The capsule logic: looks from the grid

- With the items above you can build: casual (t-shirt + trousers + sneakers), smart casual (OCBD + trousers + leather shoes), smart casual 2 (crewneck + trousers + leather shoes), casual 2 (t-shirt + jeans + sneakers), smart casual 3 (OCBD layered + t-shirt underneath + trousers).
- Five looks, eight or nine items. That is the capsule math.
- You do not need more; you need every item to fit.
- Fit check applies to every item in the capsule before you finalize the plan.

Building toward the capsule over time

- The capsule is not a one-time purchase. It is a framework for buying.
- Each new purchase should enter the capsule by replacing an item or adding a new look.
- If you cannot name two looks the new item belongs to before you buy it, do not buy it yet.
- Sacawa (He Spoke Style, 2022): a wardrobe built with proportion and fit in mind compounds over time. Every good-fitting item makes the next choice easier.

In fashion, color theory is not about painting. It is about understanding color temperature and relationships so you can build outfits that either contrast or harmonize deliberately, rather than by accident.

<footer>Justine Leconte, "COLOR THEORY basics FOR FASHION" (2017)</footer>

Take-aways

1. Undertone (warm, cool, neutral) determines which neutrals and accent colors sit well against your skin. The vein test and the gold/silver test take 30 seconds.
2. Contrast level determines how bold your color combinations should be. High contrast supports bold pairings; low contrast calls for tonal ones.
3. The three-color rule is a beginner constraint that prevents chaos. One neutral, one secondary color, one accent.
4. Know the four context registers. Dressing one register above the occasion is safe; two above is usually wrong.
5. A five-look capsule is eight or nine items. The constraint is fit, not brand or price.

What's next

- **Section (this week):** Tinder-style wardrobe audit: photograph every top, run the fit check, begin your capsule sketch
- **HW4 (out now):** Five-look capsule wardrobe plan, due Week 9. The section worksheet is your first draft.
- **Capstone (out now):** Personal twelve-week plan and before-and-after, due Week 10
- **Week 8:** Grooming and finishing: facial hair, eyebrows, fragrance, and the details that signal care